

A 1934 seven-seater Lockheed
5C Vega monoplane



Great Manufacturers Lockheed

Lockheed's pioneering design and innovative construction techniques fueled the creation of a series of successful aircraft that have outperformed their rivals. From the C-130 Hercules military transport to the F-117 Nighthawk, the company's planes have made a great contribution to the development of aviation.

THE LOCKHEED STORY began in 1912 when two brothers, Allan and Malcolm Loughead, formed the Alco Hydro-Aeroplane Company in Santa Barbara, California. This company later became the Loughead Aircraft Manufacturing Company, but did not enjoy commercial success, although it produced the innovative S-1 Sports Biplane in 1920. Malcolm left the aviation business in 1919, and Allan began to work with Jack Northrop (see pp.272–73). The pair went on to develop a breakthrough design, the Lockheed Vega (of which 141 were built). The Vega incorporated a novel monocoque fuselage construction, with a layered plywood “skin” fixed



Malcolm and Allan Loughead
(1889–1969 and 1887–1958)

onto a ribbed internal arrangement. First flown in 1927, the Vega is still remembered today because it was flown by two of aviation's true trailblazers—Amelia Earhart and Wiley Post—whose distance records showcased the type's impressive long range. After years of disappointment, Allan Loughead—

by this time heading the Lockheed Aircraft Company—had finally produced a winning design. The use of “Lockheed” in the company name instead of “Loughead” was a reflection of how the brothers' name was pronounced.

The Lockheed Aircraft Company collapsed in 1929, by which time both Jack Northrop and Allan Loughead had moved on to new ventures. It was saved by a group of investors and renamed the Lockheed Aircraft Corporation. In 1931 this group watched the Orion airliner make its maiden flight. This was the first plane to use a retractable undercarriage in commercial aircraft design.

In 1934, the twin-engined Lockheed 10 Electra emerged. It was a successful design, with 149 machines built. The Electra formed the basis for a number of subsequent designs, including the Electra Junior, the Super Electra, and the Lockheed Hudson maritime patrol aircraft—the most successful by far. Close to 3,000 Hudsons were produced in many versions, and served with a number of air forces and navies. Its replacement, the Ventura, was a larger and heavier

“It takes a Lockheed to beat a Lockheed.”

ALLAN LOCKHEED, COINING THE COMPANY SLOGAN IN 1928

aircraft, and was also produced in multiple variants. The Ventura was, in turn, replaced by the P-2 Neptune from 1947 onward.

Lockheed's greatest World War II success came with the P-38 Lightning series, with more than 10,000 being built. Unconventional in design, the distinctive, twin-boomed P-38 served as an escort fighter, ground-attack aircraft, night-fighter, and photo reconnaissance craft. Working in partnership with US airline TWA, Lockheed produced the four-engined L-049 Constellation airliner, whose combination of speed, endurance, and capacity revolutionized air travel. The company also produced the USAF's first operational jet fighter, the P-80

Lockheed P-38 Lightning

The P-38 was a large, single-seat twin-engined fighter that was used by the USAAF during World War II. A long-range fighter, it was engaged with great success in the Pacific.



Lockheed civilian aircraft

This 1941 advertisement shows the Lockheed 18 Lodestar being used to carry passengers over the Victoria Falls in southern Africa. The same model was also used by the military.

